CASE FILE · NO. 001 · PROTOTYPE

Sketchy ALIBIS

Draw your alibi. Defend your story. Catch the liar.

Player Guide & Technical Overview

A four-player social-deduction murder mystery played in the browser. Three players hold true alibis. One is lying. Everyone has to draw what they saw, and the evidence will catch whoever made it up.

4	4:15	7	1
PLAYERS	MINUTES PER CASE	STAGES	MURDERER

BUILD
Private local prototype

CREATED BY
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FILE 01 · The pitch

What is Sketchy Alibis?

Sketchy Alibis is a four-player social-deduction murder mystery. Three players receive innocent alibis. One player is secretly the **murderer** and picks one of two fabricated stories to hide behind.

Everyone studies the same location photograph, draws the details their private alibi demands, then compares drawings against the shared records. Finally, each player privately votes on two things: **which country** the scene is in, and **who did it**.

THE CORE LOOP

01
OBSERVE
Study the crime-scene photograph and your secret alibi.

02
SKETCH
Draw the two details your story requires.

03
INTERROGATE
Compare drawings, alibis and evidence records.

04
ACCUSE
Vote privately on the country and the culprit.

IF YOU ARE INNOCENT
Name the correct country and catch the player whose alibi conflicts with the evidence.

IF YOU ARE THE MURDERER
Sell your forged story, blend in with the innocents, and avoid arrest.

The game is designed for exactly four distinct player seats.

FILE 02 · Setup

Install and launch the game

REQUIRES	VERIFIED ON
Node.js 24.x · npm 11.x	Node 24.19.0 · npm 11.9.0

1. Extract `sketchy-alibis-source.zip`.
2. Open a terminal in the extracted `sketchy-alibis` folder (the one containing `package.json`).
3. Run these three commands, in order:

```
sketchy-alibis
$ npm ci
$ npm run build
$ npm start
```

Keep the terminal open while you play. On the same computer, open **http://127.0.0.1:3000**. This is a local address on your machine, not a public website.

Port 3000 already taken? Start on another port instead:

```
alternate port
$ PORT=3002 npm start
# then open http://127.0.0.1:3002
```

Troubleshooting

- Check your versions with `node --version` and `npm --version`.
- Confirm the terminal is in the folder that contains `package.json`.
- Re-run `npm ci` for a clean dependency install.

> **DON'T RESTART MID-GAME**
> Room and case state live in server memory. Restarting the server during a game you want to keep will erase it.

FILE 03 · Lobby

Create a room and join

1. **Host:** enter your player name and select **Create room**. You'll receive a six-character room code.
2. **Each of the other three players:** enter a distinct name plus the room code, then select **Join room**.
3. Check that all four names appear and every player shows as connected.
4. Every player selects **Ready**.
5. Once all four players are connected and ready, the host selects **Start case**.

Lobby rules

- A fifth player cannot join. The room is capped at four seats.
- Before the case starts, the host can remove a player or close the room. Guests can leave.
- Any join, leave or removal clears everyone's readiness, so players may need to select **Ready** again.

FILE 04 · Solo walkthrough

Trying it alone

You can explore the full interface without a group by driving four separate **Chrome browser profiles** yourself.

1. Create four Chrome profiles.
2. Open the local game once in each profile, using a different name in each.
3. Create the room in the first profile, then join from the other three.

PROFILES, NOT TABS

Ordinary tabs in the same browser profile share **one** player seat, and multiple incognito windows share one incognito session. Use four separate profiles.

Don't use **Resume** to create another player. Resume takes over an existing seat.

SPOILER WARNING

A solo walkthrough shows you all four private cards, which spoils the mystery. Use it to learn the controls and check the screens, not to judge whether the deduction is fair or fun.

FILE 05 · Gameplay

The game, stage by stage

CASE TIMELINE · 255 SECONDS

INSPECT 45s	SKETCH 40s	GALLERY 30s	INTERROGATE 90s	VERDICT 20s	SOLUTION 30s

0:00 START ▲ evidence drops at 2:20 COMPLETE 4:15

CLOCK RULES

The clock never pauses, even if players switch windows or disconnect. A saved draft auto-locks when Sketch ends, and a player who didn't submit a drawing can still vote.

STAGE	TIME	WHAT TO DO
01 **Inspect**	45 sec	Read your private alibi and its two required drawing details. Open **Photograph**, then zoom and pan around the scene; reset to the full image when done. **Murderer:** choose Forgery A or B. No choice means A is assigned automatically.
02 **Sketch**	40 sec	Draw both required details on the black-pen canvas. Use **Undo stroke** or **Clear drawing** as needed. Add an optional caption (max five words, 80 characters). **Save draft** keeps work in progress; **Submit and lock** locks it immediately.
03 **Gallery**	30 sec	Review everyone's locked drawings and captions. Save your initial country and suspect picks. These are private first impressions for the debrief and don't affect points.
04 **Interrogate**	90 sec	Discuss drawings and alibis. The shared **Evidence** sheet appears 25 seconds in. Compare the Portugal and Spain columns with each story. Talk in person or on a separate call; there is no built-in chat or voice.
05 **Verdict**	20 sec	Choose a country and a player to accuse (accusation may be left blank). Add an optional reason, up to 160 characters, and save. Initial choices do not carry over.
06 **Solution**	30 sec	Open **Results**: murderer, correct country, forgery used, vote tally, scores, original cards, both forgery options, clues, explanation and photograph attribution.
07 **Complete**	1 hour	Final results stay available for one hour. There is no rematch button; create a new room for another run.

FILE 06 · Host eyes only

Case 001: The Last Take

SPOILERS AHEAD

This section reveals the answer, the clues and the evidence records. Players who want a fair game should skip to File 07.

INCIDENT REPORT

A travel-show host is found dead behind a café at **9:05 p.m.** Each player must account for their whereabouts at **9:00 p.m.**

The photograph is an earlier daytime street image near the fictional scene. It does not show who was present or what was open at 9:00 p.m. The victim, café, hotel, fountain, stop, alibis and production records are all fictional; real people and businesses visible in the photograph are unrelated to the story.

Where in the world?

Six country options. One is correct.

Portugal ✓	Spain	France	Italy	Netherlands	United Kingdom

The photograph contains two clue families: the tram destination **PRAZERES 28E**, and Portuguese shop lettering including **RELÓGIOS**. Clue interpretations and source attribution are revealed only during the Solution stage.

The alibis

Three innocent alibis are dealt once each. The murderer chooses one of two forgeries. Every card requires two drawn details.

INNOCENT	Delivering pastries to the café receiving entrance
INNOCENT	Repairing a bicycle beside the fountain
INNOCENT	Collecting a parcel from the hotel desk
FORGERY A	Boarding a tram at the café stop
FORGERY B	Buying pastries at the café sales counter

The evidence sheet

Released **140 seconds** after Start (25 seconds into Interrogate), the sheet compares fictional records for two candidate countries:

RECORD	PORTUGAL	SPAIN
Tram stop	Closed from 8:45 p.m.	Open until 9:30 p.m.
Café sales counter	Closed from 8:30 p.m.	Open until 9:30 p.m.
Receiving entrance	Deliveries until 9:15 p.m.	Deliveries ended 8:45 p.m.

These are invented case records, not real business or transit hours.

FILE 07 · Rules

Scoring

+2	**Correct country** Any player who selects **Portugal**.
+3	**Correct accusation** An innocent player who accuses the murderer.
+3	**Murderer escapes** The murderer, if they are not uniquely arrested.

TIEBREAK RULES

A tie for the most votes means **no arrest**.

The player or players with the highest total score share the win.

FILE 08 · Interface

Controls and features

01

Private player panel

Shows only your own role, alibi and required drawing details until the reveal.

02

Room code & readiness

Private rooms, six-character invite code, four seats, Ready status and host controls.

03

Role & alibi assignment

The server randomly deals one murderer and three innocent cards. Only the murderer sees the two forgery choices.

04

Photograph viewer

Zoom up to 8×, drag to pan, reset, arrow-key panning, and retry if the image fails to load.

05

Drawing canvas

Black-pen freehand drawing, Undo stroke, Clear drawing, short caption, draft saving and explicit submit-and-lock.

06

Autosave & locking

Drafts show save status. Submitted drawings lock immediately; saved drafts lock at the Sketch deadline.

07

Gallery

Displays all four drawings, captions and missing-sketch states after Sketch ends.

08

Evidence sheet

Releases the shared Portugal/Spain records at the scheduled point in Interrogate.

09

Private ballots

Separate initial choices and final verdict. Initial choices earn no points and don't transfer.

10

Results & debrief

Murderer, country, selected forgery, vote tally, score breakdown, cards, clue explanations and photo credit.

11

Connection recovery

Reconnects the same browser seat where possible and flags unconfirmed saves. The clock keeps running.

FILE 09 · Engineering

Technology stack

LAYER	TECHNOLOGY	HOW IT IS USED
FRONTEND	`React 19 + React DOM`	Component-based UI and interactive screens.
LANGUAGE	`TypeScript 7`	Typed frontend, shared contracts and backend code.
BUILD	`Vite 8`	Frontend dev server and production build tooling.
SERVER	`Node.js 24 + Express 5`	HTTP server, API routes and application runtime.
REALTIME	`Socket.IO 4`	Live lobby and game communication over WebSockets.
VALIDATION	`Zod 4`	Runtime validation of room actions, game requests, captions, drawings and ballots.
DRAWING	`react-sketch-canvas 8`	Interactive freehand drawing canvas.
PHOTO	`@panzoom/panzoom 4`	Photograph zooming and panning.
TESTING	`Vitest 5`	Unit and integration tests.
E2E	`Playwright 1.64`	Browser end-to-end tests with independent player contexts.

ENGINEERING SKILLS DEMONSTRATED

- Full-stack web development
- Typed API & event contracts
- Real-time multiplayer systems
- Server-authoritative game state
- Session & room authorization
- Privacy boundaries for hidden info
- Timed state machines
- Concurrency & retry handling
- Drawing/photo UI integration
- Input validation
- Reconnect & failure handling
- Unit, integration & browser testing
- Technical documentation

FILE 10 · Status

Current limitations and verification status

SCOPE	Private local prototype. No public deployment or remote preview is provided.
STATE	One Node process with in-memory room state. Restarting the server destroys active rooms and results.
CONTENT	One approved case only. No rematch or case-selection menu.
COMMS	No built-in voice chat, text chat or pause feature.
SOLO TESTING	Four distinct browser profiles are required for a solo four-seat walkthrough.
PLAYTESTING	Four-human group playtests and physical-device checks were explicitly deferred. Automated browser tests do not show that real players find the game fair, fun or easy to use.

APPROVAL STAMP

`case-001@1.0.0-rc.1`

Approved by Atman Ainapure on 15 October 2026 for prototype rehearsal only. **This is not production-readiness approval.**

FILE 11 · Operations

Stop and start a fresh run

1. Stop the server with **Ctrl+C** in its terminal.
2. Start it again with `npm start`.
3. Refresh all four browser profiles.
4. Create a new room and have the other profiles join.

> **NO GOING BACK**
> The old room and its results cannot be restored after a server restart, and there is no rematch within the same room.

FILE 12 · Testing

Developer verification commands

```
verification
$ npm run typecheck
$ npm run build
$ npm test
$ npm run test:e2e
$ npm run check   # all of the above, in sequence
```

`npm run check` runs typecheck, build, Vitest and Playwright in sequence. Playwright requires its matching Chromium installation.

Recorded evidence

See the included docs for recorded evidence and explicit deferrals:

- `docs/SB-05-real-case-rehearsal.md`
- `docs/SB-09-private-demo.md`
- `docs/SB-07-device-check.md`

— case closed —